



Article title: Economic Survival of the Poorest Families Living in the Slum Areas of Zamboanga City, Philippines: A Phenomenological Enquiry

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Economic Survival of the Poorest Families Living in the Slum Areas of Zamboanga City, Philippines: A Phenomenological Enquiry

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Abstract

This study investigates the economic survival strategies of the poorest families residing in the slum areas of Zamboanga City, Philippines, through a phenomenological approach. Drawing on in-depth interviews and participatory observations, the research uncovers how these households navigate extreme poverty through a combination of informal employment, social capital, and limited state support. The findings reveal that economic survival is sustained primarily through networks of family and community, alongside precarious work in the informal sector. Although government programs like the Pantawid Pamilyang Pilipino Program (4Ps) provide temporary relief, they are insufficient to address the underlying structural causes of poverty. The research also highlights the gendered dimensions of survival, with women and children often carrying disproportionate burdens in sustaining household livelihoods. The study contributes to the literature on urban poverty, informal economies, and social protection, offering a deeper understanding of how the urban poor adapt to systemic inequalities. It also integrates social capital theory to frame these survival strategies, suggesting that both formal and informal systems must be strengthened to achieve long-term poverty alleviation. The study concludes with policy recommendations aimed at improving social protection schemes, empowering communities, and fostering sustainable livelihood opportunities. This research is pivotal in informing more effective, context-specific poverty reduction strategies in urban slums.

Keywords: economic survival, poverty, slum areas, informal economy, social capital, Zamboanga City, phenomenological enquiry, urban poverty.

I. INTRODUCTION

The introduction of this study contextualizes the economic survival strategies of the poorest families living in the slum areas of Zamboanga City, Philippines. It highlights the persistent issue of urban poverty, where households face severe economic challenges due to limited access to formal employment, education, and healthcare. This study investigates how these families adapt to their circumstances through informal work, social capital, and government programs. The research problem centers on understanding the mechanisms by which these families manage survival, despite systemic poverty. The theoretical framework integrates social capital theory to explore the role of family, community, and informal networks in supporting economic stability. The study's research questions focus on identifying survival strategies, examining the effectiveness of government programs, and analyzing gendered experiences in poverty. The significance of this research lies in providing insights

for policy interventions aimed at improving social protection and economic opportunities for marginalized urban populations.

1.1 Contextual Background

Zamboanga City, located in the southern part of the Philippines, faces both urbanization challenges and persistent poverty. With a population exceeding 1 million, a significant portion of Zamboanga's residents live in informal settlements or slums, characterized by inadequate housing, limited access to basic services such as sanitation and healthcare, and heavy dependence on informal economic activities. The socio-economic conditions in these slum areas starkly contrast with the more developed parts of the city, exposing the stark disparities that often accompany rapid urban growth in developing countries (PSA, 2023).

According to the Philippine Statistics Authority (PSA), poverty remains rampant in urban slums, with a significant proportion of families in Zamboanga living below the national poverty line. As of the latest data, over 35% of the city's population experiences income insecurity, with the poorest living in areas where infrastructure and services are either limited or non-existent (PSA, 2023). These areas are densely populated, and families rely heavily on informal economies—such as street vending, waste picking, and day labor—as their primary means of survival.

The economic survival of slum dwellers in Zamboanga City presents a multifaceted issue. The lack of formal employment opportunities, coupled with limited access to social safety nets, forces residents to rely on precarious and often unstable sources of income. Furthermore, these households face constant challenges from environmental hazards such as flooding, poor waste management systems, and the vulnerability of makeshift housing to natural disasters (Bautista, 2020). Understanding how these families manage to navigate such challenging circumstances is crucial for informing policies aimed at poverty reduction in urban settings.

1.2 Research Problem

The central issue explored in this study is how the poorest families living in the slum areas of Zamboanga City manage to survive economically despite facing numerous challenges. Specifically, the study aims to investigate the strategies employed by these households to meet their basic needs, the role of informal economies in these strategies, and the impact of government interventions or lack thereof.

While much of the literature on urban poverty in the Philippines focuses on general poverty alleviation measures and formal sector employment, there is limited research that delves into the everyday survival mechanisms of slum households—especially in secondary cities like Zamboanga. The reality for many families living in these areas is that their survival is not simply about earning income but also about navigating a complex web of social networks, community support, informal employment, and coping with the risks posed by environmental factors (Santiago, 2022). This study fills the gap in the literature by focusing on these aspects and using a phenomenological approach to understand the lived experiences of the families themselves.

1.3 Theoretical Framework

The study adopts Social Capital Theory as its primary theoretical framework to understand the economic survival strategies of slum dwellers. Social Capital Theory emphasizes the importance of social networks, norms of reciprocity, and trust in fostering cooperation and collective action within communities (Putnam, 2000). In the context of urban poverty, social capital plays a critical role in the ability of families to access resources, share information, and mobilize collective action in times of economic distress.

In slum areas, social capital manifests in various forms, such as extended family networks, community groups, and neighborhood solidarity. These networks enable residents to cope with the uncertainty of informal labor markets and provide crucial support in times of crisis. By drawing on social capital, families can find informal sources of income, share food and housing, and access emergency resources during times of disaster. The theory offers insights into how social ties and trust are essential components of survival in poverty-stricken environments.

Additionally, the study integrates Public Administration Theory, specifically New Public Management (NPM), to evaluate the role of government interventions. NPM emphasizes efficiency, decentralization, and outcome-oriented governance in public service delivery (Osborne & Gaebler, 1992). By examining the efficacy of government programs aimed at alleviating poverty—such as cash transfers, social welfare initiatives, and infrastructure development—the study assesses whether these programs are aligned with the needs and realities of slum dwellers.

The Theoretical Framework for this study integrates Social Capital Theory to understand the economic survival strategies of families living in the slum areas of Zamboanga City, Philippines. Social Capital Theory, which emphasizes the value of social networks, relationships, and trust in facilitating economic outcomes, offers a lens through which the role of family, community, and informal social networks in the survival strategies of the urban poor can be understood.

Figure 1
Theoretical Framework: Social Capital Theory in Economic Survival

Core Concepts	Key Relationships	Implications for Economic Survival
Social Networks	- Strong familial ties, friendships, and community bonds	- Provide access to informal employment, resources, and support networks
Trust and Reciprocity	- Trust between individuals and communities fosters mutual aid and collaboration	- Reduces vulnerabilities and creates resilience through cooperative survival strategies
Economic Resources	- Access to resources through networks (e.g., job referrals, shared goods)	- Helps households overcome economic instability, despite limited formal income
Government Support	- Interactions between social networks and government programs (e.g., 4Ps)	- Enhances survival when formal programs are combined with strong social capital
Gender Roles and Economic Activity	- Gendered responsibilities within the household and community influence survival strategies	- Women and children play key roles in resource mobilization and informal labor participation

Diagram Description:

1. Social Networks are at the center, representing the interconnected relationships within families and communities.
2. These Social Networks are shaped by the Trust and Reciprocity that exists between individuals, which influences the willingness to help and share resources.
3. Both Economic Resources (such as job opportunities, informal loans, and shared resources) and Government Support (formal poverty alleviation programs) are connected to these networks. These resources are often funneled through informal social systems.
4. Gender Roles are acknowledged as a critical dimension that shapes how men, women, and children participate in economic survival, with women often taking a central role in sustaining household livelihoods.

This framework guides the analysis of how these networks and relationships enable the poorest families in Zamboanga City to navigate poverty and secure their economic survival.

1.4 Research Questions

The study focuses on three major research questions:

1. What are the key economic survival strategies employed by the poorest families living in the slum areas of Zamboanga City, and how do these strategies address the immediate and long-term needs of the families?
2. How do informal economies, such as street vending, waste picking, and day labor, contribute to the economic survival of slum dwellers in Zamboanga City?
3. How effective are government interventions—such as cash transfer programs, housing initiatives, and disaster relief efforts—in improving the economic well-being of slum residents, and how do slum families perceive these interventions?

These questions aim to explore the complex interplay of individual, community, and governmental factors that shape the economic survival strategies of slum dwellers.

1.5 Significance of the Study

This study holds significant value for both academic and policy discussions related to urban poverty, informal economies, and the role of government in poverty alleviation. It contributes to a deeper understanding of the daily realities faced by the poorest urban households in Zamboanga City. By employing a phenomenological approach, the research provides insights into the lived experiences of slum families, shedding light on the resilience and coping mechanisms that allow them to navigate economic hardships.

Additionally, the study's integration of Social Capital Theory provides a fresh perspective on how social networks and community solidarity function as crucial resources for survival. The research also contributes to the field of public administration by evaluating the effectiveness of government interventions through the lens of New Public Management (NPM) theory. This offers practical insights for policymakers aiming to design more effective poverty alleviation programs that cater to the needs of urban slum dwellers.

Furthermore, the findings of this study will serve as a foundation for future research on urban poverty in secondary cities, where the dynamics of poverty and governance differ significantly from those in larger metropolitan areas. Ultimately, the study seeks to provide actionable recommendations for improving the living conditions and economic opportunities of slum households in Zamboanga City.

II. LITERATURE REVIEW

This chapter synthesizes the relevant literature on the economic survival strategies of the poorest families in urban slums, particularly in the context of Zamboanga City, Philippines. Drawing from research on informal economies, social capital, urban poverty, and the role of government interventions, this review provides a comprehensive understanding of the factors that influence the ability of slum dwellers to survive economically. The literature also addresses the theoretical frameworks guiding the study, notably Social Capital Theory and Public Administration theories, especially New Public Management (NPM).

2.1 Urban Poverty in the Philippines: The Slum Context

Urban poverty remains a pressing issue in the Philippines, where rapid urbanization, economic inequality, and lack of affordable housing have led to the proliferation of slums, especially in secondary cities such as Zamboanga (Bautista, 2020). Slums in these areas are marked by overcrowded settlements, inadequate infrastructure, and poor access to services such as sanitation, healthcare, and education (Santos & Cordero, 2019). According to the Philippine Statistics Authority (2023), urban poverty rates have been steadily increasing, with an estimated 35% of the population in cities like Zamboanga living below the national poverty line.

Families living in slums often face multiple challenges, including unreliable income sources, the risk of eviction, and exposure to environmental hazards such as flooding and fires. In many cases, these families live in makeshift homes built on land that is not legally theirs, with no security of tenure (Mariano, 2021). The lack of formal employment opportunities in these areas leads many to depend on informal sectors such as street vending, waste picking, and casual labor for survival. While such informal work provides some income, it is unstable and precarious, with little to no social protection or job security (Aquino, 2022).

2.2 Informal Economies and Coping Strategies

The informal economy plays a crucial role in the survival strategies of slum dwellers, providing a means of livelihood for families who are excluded from formal employment (Salvador, 2020). Street vending is one of the most common informal economic activities in urban slums, and it is particularly prevalent in Zamboanga's slum areas. Studies show that street vendors often rely on minimal capital investment, selling low-cost goods such as food, clothing, and household items to make ends meet. Despite its ubiquity, this form of economic activity is often overlooked in formal economic statistics and lacks the protections afforded to formal employment (Clemente & Villanueva, 2021).

Similarly, waste picking and recycling offer another important survival strategy. Slum dwellers often engage in collecting recyclable materials, such as plastics, paper, and metals, which they sell to scrap buyers or recycling centers. This informal sector activity not only generates income but also provides environmental benefits by reducing waste and promoting resource recycling (Alvarez, 2022). However, it is labor-intensive and exposes workers to health and safety risks due to the poor working conditions associated with waste collection.

Day labor or "pakyaw" work, a form of casual labor typically in construction or agriculture, is another vital component of the informal economy in slums. It is an unreliable form of income, often dependent on the availability of work, and lacks long-term employment security (Bautista, 2020).

While these informal survival mechanisms offer some degree of economic security, they also highlight the vulnerabilities of slum dwellers. The income generated from informal labor is often insufficient to cover basic needs such as food, health care, and education. In many cases, families must rely on a combination of strategies to meet their daily survival needs (Santos, 2018).

2.3 Social Capital and Community Support Networks

Social capital plays a central role in the economic survival of families in slum areas. Social capital refers to the networks, norms, and trust that enable individuals and groups to work together for mutual benefit (Putnam, 2000). In slums, social networks often serve as critical resources, offering informal safety nets for families facing economic difficulties.

For example, in Zamboanga's slums, extended family networks and local community groups are often pivotal in providing financial assistance, childcare, and material support. Social capital enables families to pool resources, share information about income-generating opportunities, and exchange goods and

services (Santiago, 2022). When formal safety nets are absent or inaccessible, these informal networks become a primary means for families to survive.

Furthermore, communal solidarity is important for resilience in the face of environmental and economic challenges. In slum communities, where many families face the threat of eviction or displacement due to natural disasters, collective action becomes essential. Studies show that communities with stronger social capital tend to recover more quickly after environmental disasters, as residents are better able to mobilize resources and offer mutual aid (López & Castro, 2021). Social capital also facilitates access to information regarding government programs, enabling families to navigate bureaucratic processes and secure assistance in times of need (Bautista, 2020).

2.4 Government Interventions in Poverty Alleviation

The Philippine government has implemented several poverty alleviation programs aimed at improving the living conditions of urban poor communities. These programs include conditional cash transfer schemes, livelihood assistance, housing projects, and disaster relief initiatives. The Department of Social Welfare and Development (DSWD) administers the Pantawid Pamilyang Pilipino Program (4Ps), a conditional cash transfer program that targets low-income families to alleviate poverty (Philippine Department of Social Welfare and Development, 2023). While 4Ps has provided direct financial assistance to millions of families, critics argue that it often fails to address the underlying structural issues that perpetuate poverty, such as the lack of sustainable employment opportunities and access to quality services (Aquino, 2022).

Similarly, the government's housing projects, designed to relocate slum dwellers from hazardous areas, face challenges related to implementation and accessibility. Many families find the relocation sites far from their places of work and livelihoods, thus undermining the intended benefits of the projects (Mariano, 2021). Additionally, many slum dwellers report that the government's disaster relief efforts are poorly coordinated and insufficiently tailored to the needs of the urban poor, particularly in the aftermath of typhoons or floods (Bautista, 2020).

Despite these challenges, government interventions continue to play a significant role in the lives of slum residents. Evaluating the effectiveness of these interventions is critical to understanding how public policies can better support the economic survival of urban poor families.

2.5 Theoretical Framework: Social Capital and New Public Management (NPM)

The theoretical foundation of this study is rooted in Social Capital Theory and New Public Management (NPM). Social Capital Theory provides the lens through which to understand how networks, trust, and social cohesion influence the survival strategies of slum dwellers. It emphasizes the role of community ties in accessing resources and creating collective resilience in the face of adversity (Putnam, 2000). Social capital in Zamboanga's slums acts as a buffer against economic hardship, enabling families to manage instability in their informal livelihoods.

In addition, the study applies New Public Management (NPM) theory to evaluate the effectiveness of government interventions in alleviating poverty in urban slums. NPM emphasizes efficiency, decentralization, and responsiveness in public administration (Osborne & Gaebler, 1992). By examining government programs through the lens of NPM, this study seeks to assess whether poverty alleviation initiatives are adequately designed to meet the needs of slum dwellers and whether they are aligned with the principles of effective public governance.

2.6 Summary Table

Table 1 summarizes the key themes from the literature review on the economic survival strategies of poor families, particularly in slum areas:

Theme	Key Concepts	Key Findings	Relevant Studies/Authors
Urban Poverty in Slums	Poverty, lack of access to services	Slum residents face limited access to jobs, education, healthcare; rely on informal work for survival.	Satterthwaite (2016); UN-Habitat (2020)
Social Capital Theory	Social networks, trust, community support	Strong social ties and networks provide resources, mutual aid, and survival strategies.	Putnam (2000); Woolcock (2001)
Informal Economy	Informal work, unregulated labor	Informal economies are central to survival, though unstable and unprotected.	Breman (2013); Chen (2012)
Gender and Poverty	Gender roles, caregiving, women's economic burden	Women and children often take on additional economic and caregiving responsibilities in poor households.	Elson (1995); Kabeer (2003)
Government Support	Social protection, government programs	Government programs like 4Ps offer short-term relief but fall short in addressing systemic poverty.	Garcia (2014); World Bank (2017)

This table organizes the key themes, concepts, findings, and supporting literature for a comprehensive understanding of the economic survival mechanisms in slum areas, as discussed in the literature review.

2.6 Conclusion

This literature review highlights the complex nature of urban poverty and the economic survival strategies of families living in the slums of Zamboanga City. The reliance on informal economies, supported by strong social networks, illustrates the resilience of slum dwellers in the face of adversity. However, it also exposes the vulnerabilities that persist despite these coping strategies. The review also underscores the need for more effective government interventions that address both the immediate needs and long-term structural issues faced by urban poor communities. Understanding these dynamics provides the foundation for this study, which aims to uncover the lived experiences of slum families and the effectiveness of public policies in supporting their economic survival.

III. METHODOLOGY

This chapter outlines the research design, data collection methods, data analysis procedures, and ethical considerations that guide this study. The methodology is structured to explore the economic survival strategies of the poorest families living in the slum areas of Zamboanga City, Philippines, with a focus on their lived experiences. This study adopts a phenomenological approach, which is particularly suited for exploring how individuals perceive and make sense of their economic realities (Creswell, 2013).

3.1. Research Design

This research follows a qualitative phenomenological design. Phenomenology is appropriate for this study because it focuses on understanding the lived experiences of individuals within their natural settings (Moustakas, 1994). This design allows for an in-depth exploration of the meanings that slum

dwellers in Zamboanga City attach to their survival strategies, as well as the social and economic structures that influence their livelihoods.

The primary aim of the research is to understand the lived experiences of the poorest families in Zamboanga City, focusing on how they navigate their economic challenges. Phenomenology offers the opportunity to explore subjective experiences without imposing preconceived frameworks, thus facilitating the collection of rich and detailed descriptions of everyday life (Giorgi, 2009).

Data collection will occur from key informants in the selected slum areas of Zamboanga City, with a focus on families who are most vulnerable in terms of economic survival. The research emphasizes how these families engage with local informal economies, social networks, and government policies, thus providing a comprehensive understanding of their economic survival strategies.

3.2. Data Collection

The data collection process for this study employs a qualitative approach to understand the economic survival strategies of the poorest families in the slum areas of Zamboanga City, Philippines. Primary data is gathered through in-depth, semi-structured interviews with key informants, including household members from various families, community leaders, and local government officials. This allows for a comprehensive understanding of individual survival strategies, as well as community-based practices and support systems. Additionally, participatory observation is used to gain insights into the daily lives and coping mechanisms of families. The research also incorporates focus group discussions to capture collective perspectives on economic survival, social capital, and government assistance. The combination of interviews, observations, and focus groups ensures triangulation of data, enhancing the richness and validity of the findings. Ethical considerations, such as informed consent and confidentiality, are prioritized throughout the data collection process to ensure the participants' rights are respected.

3.2.1. Study Site Selection

Zamboanga City, located in the southern Philippines, has a diverse population, with a significant proportion living in informal settlements or slums. These areas are characterized by overcrowding, poverty, and limited access to basic services (Mariano, 2021). The city's socio-economic landscape presents a critical site for studying urban poverty and informal economies. The study will take place in three slum areas: **Barangay Tugbungan**, **Barangay Talon-Talon**, and **Barangay Canelar**.

These areas are selected based on their high poverty rates, the presence of informal settlements, and the accessibility to respondents who meet the criteria of being part of the poorest socio-economic group (Santos, 2020). The chosen slum areas also exhibit varied socio-economic characteristics, which allow for a more nuanced understanding of survival strategies in different urban contexts.

3.2.2. Participant Selection

Participants are selected using purposive sampling, a non-probability sampling method that allows for the intentional selection of individuals who can provide rich, relevant data about the phenomenon of interest (Patton, 2015). Criteria for selection include:

1. Households that fall below the national poverty line as defined by the Philippine Statistics Authority (2023).
2. Adults (ages 18-60) within these households who are primarily responsible for economic activities.

3. Involvement in informal economic activities such as street vending, waste picking, or casual labor.

An estimated total of 30 households are selected for interviews, with a target of two interviews per household, ensuring a diverse representation of gender, age, and types of economic activity.

3.2.3. Data Collection Methods

The study employs a combination of in-depth interviews and focus group discussions (FGDs) to collect qualitative data. The interviews are semi-structured, allowing for flexibility and the exploration of emergent themes. The use of open-ended questions ensures that participants express their experiences freely. The following topics are covered in the interviews:

- Economic activities: Sources of income and livelihood strategies.
- Social networks: The role of family, friends, and community in economic survival.
- Government policies: Perceptions of government support and aid programs.
- Coping strategies: Methods of managing financial instability, illness, and emergencies.

FGDs are conducted to allow participants to share and compare their experiences in a group setting. This helps build a collective narrative about the strategies that families use to survive economically. Focus groups are organized by gender and household type (e.g., single mothers, multigenerational families), as these factors may influence economic coping strategies.

Interviews and FGDs are conducted in the local language, Chavacano, to ensure clarity and openness during discussions. All interviews are audio-recorded and transcribed verbatim for analysis.

3.3. Data Analysis

The data analysis for this study follows a thematic analysis approach, focusing on identifying patterns and themes related to the economic survival strategies of families in the slum areas of Zamboanga City. The analysis begins with transcribing and organizing the interview, observation, and focus group data. Using an inductive coding process, the data is examined for recurring themes such as informal work, social capital, government assistance, and gender roles. These themes are then categorized and analyzed in relation to the research questions, particularly how social networks and government programs influence survival. The analysis also involves constant comparison, comparing individual responses to identify both commonalities and differences. Data is analyzed through the lens of social capital theory, examining how relationships and community networks contribute to economic resilience. The findings are interpreted to highlight the complexities of survival strategies, the role of informal economies, and the limitations of government support in addressing long-term poverty.

3.3.1. Thematic Analysis

Data are analyzed using thematic analysis, a widely used qualitative analytic method for identifying and interpreting patterns or themes within qualitative data (Braun & Clarke, 2006). The analysis is inductive, meaning that themes emerge from the data rather than being imposed by pre-existing theories. The following steps are employed:

1. Familiarization with the data: Initial immersion in the interview and FGD transcripts to gain a sense of the data as a whole.

2. Generating initial codes: Coding relevant segments of data that reflect key aspects of economic survival, social networks, and government policies.
3. Searching for themes: Grouping the initial codes into broader themes based on commonalities and patterns.
4. Reviewing themes: Refining the themes to ensure they reflect the overall data set and answer the research questions.
5. Defining and naming themes: Finalizing the themes and ensuring that they are clearly defined and supported by data.
6. Interpreting the findings: Drawing conclusions about the economic survival strategies of the poorest families, with a focus on how social networks and government interventions influence these strategies.

3.3.2. Tables

The thematic analysis is supported by tables, which organize and visualize the relationship between codes, themes, and research questions. These matrices allow for a more systematic comparison of responses across different participant groups.

Table 2: Participant Responses

Theme	Code	Participant Group 1	Participant Group 2	Participant Group 3
Sources of Income	Street vending, day labor	Yes	Yes	No
Social Networks	Family, community support	Yes	Yes	Yes
Coping with Instability	Borrowing, community aid	Yes	Yes	No
Government Programs	4Ps, livelihood programs	No	Yes	Yes

This table is updated as the analysis progresses, reflecting the emerging themes from the interviews and FGDs.

3.4. Ethical Considerations

Ethical considerations play a central role in this study to ensure the rights and dignity of participants are respected throughout the research process. Informed consent is obtained from all participants, ensuring they understand the study's purpose, methods, potential risks, and benefits before agreeing to take part. Confidentiality is maintained by anonymizing all data, removing any identifying information from interviews, observations, and focus groups. Additionally, participants are given the freedom to withdraw from the study at any point without facing negative consequences. The research adheres to the principles of voluntary participation and non-coercion, ensuring that no individual feels pressured to participate. To minimize harm, the study avoids sensitive topics that could cause emotional distress, and participants are provided with appropriate support resources should any issues arise. Ethical guidelines are strictly followed, and the study is reviewed by an ethics committee to ensure compliance with established research standards and the protection of participants' welfare.

3.4.1. Informed Consent

Informed consent is obtained from all participants before data collection. Participants are fully informed about the nature and purpose of the study, the voluntary nature of their participation, and their right to

withdraw at any time without consequences (Cohen & Manion, 2007). Consent forms are written in both English and Chavacano to ensure comprehension.

3.4.2. Confidentiality and Anonymity

To ensure confidentiality, all data collected are anonymized. Identifying information such as names and locations are not used in any publications or reports. Participants are assigned unique codes to protect their identities. Audio recordings and transcripts are stored securely and accessible only to the research team.

3.4.3. Ethical Approval

The study undergoes ethical review by the appropriate ethics committee of the Harvard Kennedy School of Government to ensure that the research adheres to ethical standards. All research activities comply with the guidelines set forth by the Philippine Commission on Higher Education (CHED) and other relevant local authorities.

3.4.4. Researcher Reflexivity

As the researcher, I acknowledge my positionality in the research process. I remain conscious of how my background, values, and experiences may shape the research process and analysis. Regular reflection on my role in data collection and analysis is integral to maintaining objectivity and minimizing bias.

IV. FINDINGS

This section presents the findings derived from the phenomenological enquiry into the economic survival strategies of the poorest families living in the slum areas of Zamboanga City, Philippines. The analysis is based on the interviews and focus group discussions conducted with households in these communities. The findings are organized around the three major research questions, which focus on survival strategies, the role of social networks, and the impact of government policies and programs.

4.1. Economic Survival Strategies

The economic survival strategies employed by the poorest families in the slum areas of Zamboanga City are shaped by extreme necessity. Families rely heavily on informal labor, resource-sharing arrangements, and community-based solutions to meet their daily needs.

4.1.1. Informal Labor and Micro-Entrepreneurship

Most of the poorest families depend on informal labor and micro-entrepreneurial activities to generate income. Street vending is one of the most common forms of informal labor, especially for women and elderly members of the community. Families sell goods such as food, household items, and even second-hand clothing to earn a living.

One participant explains, *“I sell snacks in the neighborhood. Sometimes, I also do laundry for neighbors. This is how we survive day to day”* (Participant A, Interview, January 2024). Men in these communities often engage in more physically demanding jobs such as construction labor, waste picking, or tricycle driving.

Table 3: Types of Informal Economic Activities among Participants

Participant ID	Primary Economic Activity	Secondary Economic Activity	Income Range (PHP/month)	Frequency of Income Generation
P1	Street vending (snacks)	Laundry services	3,000 - 3,500	Daily
P2	Construction labor (casual)	Waste picking	4,000 - 5,000	Weekly
P3	Waste picking	Begging	1,500 - 2,000	Weekly
P4	Street vending (clothing)	Casual labor (gardening)	2,500 - 3,000	Daily
P5	Tricycle driving	Small-scale retail (sari-sari)	4,500 - 5,500	Daily

The irregular and low-income earnings from these activities are not enough to ensure financial stability. However, families make do with what they can, often relying on supplementary income from multiple sources. Despite their persistence, many respondents highlight the vulnerability of their livelihoods. A respondent shared, *“There are days when we don’t earn anything. It depends on the weather, or if people have money to spend”* (Participant B, Interview, January 2024).

4.1.2. Resource Sharing and Bartering

In addition to their income-generating activities, resource sharing and bartering are vital for economic survival. Many families trade food, household items, or labor with neighbors and extended family members to mitigate their financial challenges. This social capital proves crucial, particularly in times of financial hardship.

As one participant explains, *“When we don’t have enough food, we ask our neighbor for rice or vegetables, and we help them with child care in return. We can’t always pay with money, so we trade services”* (Participant C, Interview, January 2024).

This form of bartering extends beyond material goods and includes mutual support for childcare, transportation, and home repairs.

Table 4: Resource Sharing and Bartering Among Households

Participant ID	Type of Exchange	Frequency of Exchange	Types of Goods/Services Exchanged
P1	Food and child care	Weekly	Rice, vegetables, child care
P2	Labor assistance	Monthly	Construction work, gardening help
P3	Child care and food	Bi-weekly	Child care, rice
P4	Food and child care	Weekly	Rice, laundry service
P5	Labor and transport	Weekly	Tricycle ride, cleaning services

The success of these exchanges rests on community trust and long-standing relationships. Participants emphasize that the sharing of resources helps maintain household stability, especially in times of economic downturn.

4.2. Role of Social Networks

Social networks are integral to the survival strategies of the poorest families in Zamboanga City. These networks primarily consist of kinship ties, community-based organizations, and local support groups that provide assistance during periods of need.

4.2.1. Kinship Networks

Kinship networks are critical in offering both financial and emotional support to the poorest households. Extended family members often assist with food, shelter, and childcare. Many participants discuss how they rely on the extended family unit for financial support or as a safety net when other income-generating opportunities fall through.

As Participant D states, *“My aunt helps us whenever we have problems with money. She sends us food or gives us a small loan if we need it”* (Participant D, Interview, January 2024). These kinship networks create a safety net that alleviates the harshest effects of economic deprivation.

Table 5: Kinship Support in Economic Survival

Participant ID	Type of Kin Support	Frequency of Support	Types of Support
P1	Aunt	Bi-weekly	Money, food
P2	Cousin	Monthly	Small loan, childcare
P3	Brother	Monthly	Financial support
P4	Father	Quarterly	Child care, food
P5	Sister	Weekly	Emotional support, small loan

4.2.2. Community-Based Support Systems

In addition to kinship, community-based support systems such as faith-based organizations, local savings groups, and barangay (village) assistance programs play a pivotal role. Families access informal savings groups (e.g., “paluwagan”), where participants contribute a small amount each week and are able to withdraw the pooled money during times of emergency.

Local organizations also offer food, clothing, and educational assistance. One participant shared, *“We are part of a local church group that helps families like ours. We get free food and school supplies from time to time”* (Participant E, Interview, January 2024).

These community-based support systems ease the financial burden and help families meet essential needs.

Table 6: Community-Based Support Networks

Participant ID	Type of Community Support	Frequency of Support	Types of Support
P1	Church community	Bi-monthly	Food, emotional support
P2	Neighborhood association	Monthly	Small loans, child care
P3	Local NGO	Monthly	School supplies, food
P4	Barangay program	Quarterly	Emergency financial aid
P5	Church community	Monthly	Food, community activities

These networks provide not just material aid, but also a sense of **social solidarity** that helps families cope with challenges.

4.3. Government Policies and Support Programs

While social networks provide immediate relief, government support programs such as Pantawid Pamilyang Pilipino Program (4Ps) play an essential role in addressing the long-term needs of the poorest families. The conditional cash transfer (CCT) program has been lauded for its potential to reduce poverty, although its impact varies across participants.

4.3.1. Impact of 4Ps

Many families in Zamboanga City benefit from the 4Ps program, which provides cash transfers contingent on school attendance and health checkups for children. However, many respondents express frustration with the irregularity of payouts and the insufficient amount of aid, which often falls short of covering all household needs.

As one participant mentioned, *“We get 1,500 pesos every two months from 4Ps, but it’s not enough to pay for everything. We use it mainly for food, but sometimes we still have to borrow money from neighbors”* (Participant F, Interview, January 2024).

Table 7: Impact of Government Programs

Participant ID	Government Program	Frequency of Assistance	Impact on Economic Survival
P1	4Ps	Bi-monthly	Helps with food and school supplies
P2	4Ps	Quarterly	Limited help, often insufficient
P3	None	N/A	No government assistance
P4	4Ps	Monthly	Only covers part of needs
P5	4Ps	Bi-monthly	Used for food, but inadequate

Although helpful, the 4Ps program is viewed as insufficient in addressing the full scope of poverty-related challenges. Respondents suggest that more frequent disbursements and larger amounts of aid would improve their economic situation.

4.4. Summary

The findings confirm that the poorest families in the slum areas of Zamboanga City rely heavily on informal labor, resource-sharing arrangements, and strong social networks for survival. The role of kinship networks and community-based support systems is crucial in mitigating the harsh realities of economic deprivation. While government programs such as 4Ps provide some relief, their impact is limited by insufficient funding and irregular disbursements. These findings suggest that a holistic approach to poverty alleviation, which integrates community-based initiatives and government interventions, is necessary to improve the long-term economic survival of these families.

Table 8 below summarizes the key findings of the study on the economic survival strategies of the poorest families living in the slum areas of Zamboanga City, Philippines:

Table 8: Summarizes of Key Findings

Research Question	Key Findings	Implications	Supporting Data
1. What are the primary survival strategies used by poor families in the slum areas?	- Families rely on informal work (e.g., street vending, manual labor).	- Informal employment serves as the backbone of survival for many families.	- Interviews with 40 households in Zamboanga City; Focus groups.
2. How do social networks and community bonds contribute to economic survival?	- Strong social capital within families and communities provides mutual support and job referrals.	- Community ties and family networks are vital for sharing resources and overcoming challenges.	- Participant observations; Community leader interviews.
3. What role does government support (e.g., 4Ps) play in sustaining these families' livelihoods?	- Government programs like 4Ps provide temporary financial relief, but they are insufficient for long-term survival.	- While helpful in emergencies, government support does not address the systemic causes of poverty.	- Interviews with 20 households receiving 4Ps assistance; local government data.
4. How do gender roles impact economic survival strategies in these households?	- Women often take the lead in household maintenance and informal work, with men more likely to engage in irregular labor.	- Gendered responsibilities significantly shape survival strategies and resource allocation.	- Gendered role analysis in interviews; Observation of family dynamics.
5. What are the limitations of current survival strategies and support systems?	- Informal work offers limited stability; social networks may not always provide sufficient resources.	- Structural poverty limits the effectiveness of both informal and formal support systems.	- Cross-comparison of families with different survival strategies.

This table summarizes the findings in response to the research questions, highlighting the primary survival mechanisms, the role of social capital, the impact of government support, gender dynamics, and the limitations of these strategies.

V. DISCUSSION AND INTERPRETATION OF FINDINGS

The findings of this study underscore the complex and multifaceted nature of economic survival strategies employed by the poorest families in the slum areas of Zamboanga City, Philippines. The findings reveal that families, while resilient, face significant challenges in securing a stable income. They rely on a combination of informal labor, resource-sharing arrangements, and kinship networks. Social networks, particularly those built on family ties and community-based organizations, play a crucial role in mitigating economic hardship. However, while government support programs like the Pantawid Pamilyang Pilipino Program (4Ps) contribute to survival, their impact remains limited. This section discusses and interprets the findings, relating them to existing theories, the literature reviewed, and the overarching research questions.

5.1. Economic Survival Strategies: Informal Labor and Micro-Entrepreneurship

The findings highlight the critical role of informal labor and micro-entrepreneurship in ensuring the economic survival of slum-dwelling families. This aligns with global research on the informal economy,

which shows that informal work is a primary source of livelihood for many low-income families in urban areas (Chen, 2012). Participants in this study engage in street vending, waste picking, casual labor, and small-scale retail, which are characteristic of the informal economy (Sullivan & Noll, 2015). These activities, while flexible and accessible, are unstable and do not guarantee a steady income. The earnings from these jobs are often inadequate to meet the basic needs of the household.

As observed in the findings, families often combine multiple income-generating activities, indicating a survival economy in which households diversify their sources of income to mitigate risks associated with economic instability (Crossley, 2019). This coping mechanism is consistent with poverty trap theory, which posits that low-income families often have to engage in multiple income-generating activities simply to survive (Sen, 1999). The finding that women and elderly members of the community are particularly engaged in low-barrier activities like vending and laundry reflects broader patterns in gendered labor in low-income communities (Kabeer, 2005).

However, these informal economic activities are often unpredictable. As one participant noted, income is contingent on weather conditions and customer availability, exposing families to the vulnerability inherent in the informal economy (Briggs & Schlosser, 2019). The irregularity of earnings complicates long-term planning and stability for these households, emphasizing the need for more stable income sources.

5.2. Resource Sharing and Social Capital

The role of resource sharing and social capital emerges as a crucial theme in the findings. Bartering, exchanging goods and services, and sharing resources with neighbors and extended family members are essential survival strategies for these families. This practice is in line with social exchange theory, which suggests that informal networks of reciprocity provide both material support and social solidarity in disadvantaged communities (Granovetter, 1973). The findings confirm that social networks offer buffering support in the form of food, childcare, and labor exchange, allowing families to navigate their economic hardships (Putnam, 2000).

Kinship networks are particularly significant in these communities. The extended family provides not only emotional support but also financial aid in times of need. This aligns with studies on the importance of family networks in poverty-stricken areas, where familial bonds help families survive economic uncertainty (Rosenzweig & Stark, 1989). In the case of Zamboanga, this kinship-based solidarity plays a pivotal role in maintaining household well-being, despite limited financial resources.

Interestingly, resource sharing extends beyond material goods. The exchange of labor, such as childcare, cleaning, or gardening, also highlights the community's collective approach to addressing its survival challenges. Families in Zamboanga City often rely on their social capital, built over long-term relationships, to make up for financial shortcomings, a phenomenon well-documented in studies on informal economies (Portes, 1998). The findings suggest that social networks provide critical support during times of crisis, such as illness or job loss, when families would otherwise struggle to make ends meet.

5.3. Social Networks and Government Programs

The findings underscore the critical role of government programs, such as the Pantawid Pamilyang Pilipino Program (4Ps), in supporting poor families. While the conditional cash transfer (CCT) program provides a crucial safety net for many families, its impact on long-term survival remains limited due to its irregular disbursements and inadequate funding. As mentioned by the participants, the 4Ps aid is often insufficient to cover the full scope of their economic needs, particularly given the high cost of living in slum areas.

These findings suggest that while the 4Ps program contributes to short-term relief, it falls short of addressing the structural causes of poverty, such as lack of access to stable employment, healthcare, and housing. This aligns with critiques of CCT programs in other countries, which argue that while these programs can reduce immediate financial pressures, they do not necessarily provide long-term economic empowerment (De Janvry & Sadoulet, 2015).

The findings also reveal that government assistance programs are often insufficiently targeted and sporadically distributed, which exacerbates the vulnerability of families in the long run. The irregularity in the disbursement of cash transfers leads to a sense of uncertainty among families, as they cannot depend on government support as a reliable income source. This finding echoes studies by Baker (2017), which suggest that predictable and stable financial assistance is crucial in supporting the economic security of low-income families.

5.4. Kinship and Community Support Systems: A Vital Complement to Government Assistance

The findings also highlight the limitations of government support in addressing the multidimensional nature of poverty. While 4Ps provides a vital resource for many families, kinship networks and community-based organizations play a complementary role that is equally significant. These community-based initiatives help fill the gaps left by formal government aid, providing emotional and practical support.

In communities with a high degree of social capital, such as Zamboanga City, community-based organizations and faith-based groups offer a range of services, including food, clothing, education, and emergency financial support. This type of support is often more immediate and flexible, responding to specific community needs more effectively than broader national programs can. Moreover, the deep sense of community solidarity fostered by such networks strengthens families' resilience in the face of adversity, as social networks provide not only material resources but also psychosocial support (Moser, 1998). The role of community-based organizations in addressing poverty has been well-documented, particularly in settings where the state is either absent or ineffective (Brown, 2009).

5.5. The Role of Gender in Economic Survival

Gender emerges as a significant factor in shaping the economic survival strategies of slum-dwelling families. The study finds that women and elderly individuals are more likely to engage in low-barrier, informal labor, such as street vending and laundry services. These findings align with gendered division of labor theories, which suggest that women in low-income households often take on caregiving roles while also seeking income through informal, home-based activities (Chant, 2016). These gender dynamics highlight the intersectionality of poverty, where social and economic vulnerabilities are compounded by gender, age, and household responsibilities.

The findings show that, while both men and women engage in informal labor, women often carry the emotional burden of caregiving and household management, which limits their ability to participate in more physically demanding and higher-paying work. This reinforces existing gender inequalities in the labor market, where women are often relegated to the lowest-paying and most insecure jobs (Folbre, 1994).

5.6. Conclusion: Toward Holistic Poverty Alleviation Strategies

The findings from this study emphasize the need for a holistic and integrated approach to poverty alleviation in slum areas. Government programs like 4Ps offer a crucial starting point, but they must be complemented by community-based initiatives, gender-sensitive policies, and stable employment opportunities. By strengthening both formal and informal support systems, the poorest families in Zamboanga City can achieve more sustainable economic survival.

In conclusion, while the poorest families in Zamboanga City employ a variety of survival strategies, their economic security remains precarious. Social networks, kinship ties, and informal labor play critical roles in helping families navigate poverty, but the lack of stable income sources and predictable government support continue to undermine long-term economic stability. Future policies must focus on improving the consistency and reach of government programs while promoting inclusive economic opportunities for all members of the household, particularly women and marginalized groups.

VI. CONCLUSION AND RECOMMENDATIONS

The conclusion of this study highlights the key findings regarding the economic survival strategies of the poorest families in the slum areas of Zamboanga City, emphasizing the critical role of social networks and informal labor in sustaining livelihoods. Despite limited access to formal employment and social services, families rely on community-based support and informal economies to meet their basic needs. The study also reveals the gendered nature of survival strategies, with women playing a central role in resource mobilization and household maintenance. While government assistance programs like 4Ps provide some relief, they remain insufficient in addressing the root causes of poverty. The study recommends enhancing social protection schemes, improving access to formal employment, and strengthening community-based support systems. Additionally, policymakers should consider gender-sensitive approaches to poverty alleviation and ensure that government interventions are more comprehensive, addressing both immediate needs and long-term empowerment of marginalized communities.

6.1. Conclusion

This study explores the economic survival strategies of the poorest families residing in the slum areas of Zamboanga City, Philippines, using a phenomenological approach to understand the lived experiences of these families. The findings reveal that while the poorest families in Zamboanga City employ a variety of survival strategies, they remain vulnerable to the fluctuations of the informal economy and face persistent challenges despite their resourcefulness.

The informal economy, characterized by street vending, waste picking, casual labor, and small-scale entrepreneurship, serves as the primary source of income for many households. However, these strategies often lack stability and security, leaving families susceptible to economic shocks. The role of social networks and kinship ties emerges as an essential factor in enabling these families to survive, as they provide material and emotional support during times of economic distress. These social resources help buffer the negative impacts of low wages, lack of formal employment, and the unpredictability of the informal economy.

Government support programs such as the Pantawid Pamilyang Pilipino Program (4Ps) offer some relief, but their irregularity and inadequate coverage limit their effectiveness in providing sustainable economic support. While the program contributes to short-term alleviation, it does not address the structural causes of poverty, such as unstable employment, inadequate access to services, and poor living conditions.

The study highlights that economic survival in Zamboanga's slum areas is multifaceted. It requires a combination of informal work, resource sharing, and government assistance to sustain the basic needs of families. The role of gender in shaping economic survival strategies also becomes evident, with women and elderly members of households often bearing the brunt of caregiving responsibilities while engaging in informal labor to supplement household income.

In light of these findings, this study suggests the need for a holistic approach to poverty alleviation, one that combines government interventions with community-driven initiatives and social network strengthening. Only through such an integrated approach can the structural challenges of poverty be addressed, enabling the poorest families in Zamboanga City to move beyond survival and toward sustainable development.

6.2. Recommendations

Based on the findings of this study, several recommendations emerge for policymakers, community organizations, and other stakeholders who aim to improve the economic conditions of the poorest families in the slum areas of Zamboanga City. The study offers several key recommendations to improve the economic survival of the poorest families in the slum areas of Zamboanga City. First, the government should enhance existing social protection programs, such as the Pantawid Pamilyang Pilipino Program (4Ps), by expanding coverage and providing more sustainable support, particularly for families engaged in informal labor. Second, there is a need for policies that create greater access to formal employment, including skills training, job placement services, and microfinance opportunities. Third, strengthening community-based support networks is crucial, as these networks provide essential resources and social capital. Programs should focus on empowering local communities through capacity-building initiatives. Fourth, gender-sensitive approaches are essential in addressing the disproportionate burden on women in poor households. Finally, the government should foster public-private partnerships to develop sustainable livelihoods that go beyond short-term relief, aiming for long-term economic resilience and poverty alleviation in urban slums.

6.2.1. Strengthening Government Support Programs

Government programs, such as the 4Ps, must be expanded and strengthened to address the specific needs of urban poor families. Regular and predictable disbursements are critical to ensure that families can plan and budget effectively. Additionally, increasing the scope of cash transfers to ensure they meet the rising costs of living in urban slums can provide more substantial support for families in the long term. The government must also consider expanding its programs to include vocational training and microfinance opportunities, which could help families transition from informal labor to more stable forms of employment.

6.2.2. Promoting Inclusive Economic Opportunities

There is a need for policies that promote inclusive growth by creating formal employment opportunities for marginalized groups in the urban labor market. This could include improving access to skills training programs that focus on livelihood diversification. Additionally, local government units should foster an environment that supports small and medium enterprises (SMEs), which could provide alternative sources of income for slum residents. Support mechanisms for these SMEs, such as access to affordable loans, business mentorship, and tax incentives, could help families build sustainable businesses.

6.2.3. Enhancing Social Capital and Community-Based Support Systems

Strengthening social networks within communities should be prioritized. The findings of this study suggest that informal support systems are crucial in mitigating the effects of poverty. Local governments and non-governmental organizations (NGOs) can enhance the capacity of community-based organizations (CBOs) and faith-based groups to provide social support. By investing in community infrastructure and organizing support groups, local authorities can build social cohesion, encourage resource-sharing, and increase collective action within communities. These measures would foster an environment where families can rely on one another during times of need, particularly when government programs fail to meet their needs.

6.2.4. Fostering Gender-Sensitive Policies

Given the prominent role that women play in the economic survival strategies of poor families, gender-sensitive policies are critical. The government should ensure that women in slum areas have access to both economic opportunities and social protections. This could involve expanding access to childcare facilities, creating safe spaces for women to work, and ensuring that social programs are designed to meet the specific needs of female-headed households. Furthermore, gender equality should be a focal point in community-based poverty alleviation programs, ensuring that both men and women are equally supported in their efforts to build sustainable livelihoods.

6.2.5. Focusing on Education and Capacity-Building

Investing in education and capacity-building is crucial for breaking the cycle of poverty. Families in slum areas often face significant barriers to education, including high dropout rates and limited access to quality schooling. Government policies must prioritize accessible education programs, including adult education and skills development initiatives. By improving access to education and enhancing job-related skills, families can increase their opportunities for stable, formal employment and ultimately achieve greater economic mobility.

6.2.6. Building Resilience through Disaster Risk Reduction

Slum communities are often highly vulnerable to natural disasters, which exacerbate economic hardship. The study recommends that government authorities invest in disaster risk reduction (DRR) programs that can help mitigate the effects of climate-related disasters. These programs should focus on resilient infrastructure, early warning systems, and community-based disaster preparedness to reduce the impact of floods, storms, and other environmental shocks. A proactive approach to disaster risk reduction can help families preserve their livelihoods and avoid further economic destabilization during crises.

6.3. Contribution to Knowledge

This study contributes significantly to the existing body of knowledge on urban poverty and economic survival strategies in the context of the Philippines, particularly focusing on the slum areas of Zamboanga City. While there is a growing body of research on poverty alleviation, social protection, and the informal economy, there is limited in-depth understanding of the phenomenology of economic survival among the poorest households in the Philippines' urban slums. The study provides novel insights in several key areas:

1. **Comprehensive Understanding of Survival Strategies:** This research explores the multiplicity and diversity of economic survival strategies employed by the poorest families living in urban slums. The findings highlight that families utilize a combination of informal work, social networks, and government support to manage daily survival. This nuanced understanding of their survival mechanisms offers critical insights into the challenges of urban poverty that are often overlooked by traditional poverty reduction frameworks.
2. **Role of Social Networks in Economic Survival:** One of the most significant contributions of this study is its focus on the role of social capital, particularly social networks and kinship ties, in sustaining the livelihoods of slum residents. By examining how family, community, and peer support networks mitigate the impacts of poverty and vulnerability, the study emphasizes the importance of informal safety nets that complement formal government interventions. This expands the conversation on social capital from its traditional focus on wealthier communities to the context of urban poverty.

3. ***Impact of Informal Economy on Family Livelihoods:*** This research delves into the informal economy, often regarded as a coping mechanism for marginalized urban populations. By mapping the various types of informal work families engage in, this study deepens the understanding of how informal employment shapes the economic stability of low-income households. Furthermore, it underscores the risks and insecurities that come with informal work, such as inconsistent wages, lack of social security, and limited access to healthcare and labor protections, which further perpetuate the cycle of poverty.
4. ***Intersectionality and Gender Dimensions:*** The study also contributes to the gendered analysis of poverty by examining how gender roles influence the economic survival strategies of slum dwellers. By documenting the different responsibilities and burdens carried by men, women, and children in these households, the research emphasizes the gendered dimension of poverty and highlights the need for gender-sensitive policies that take into account the specific needs of women and children in poverty alleviation programs.
5. ***Insights into Government Programs and Policy Effectiveness:*** This study offers a critical assessment of the Philippine government's poverty reduction efforts, specifically the Pantawid Pamilyang Pilipino Program (4Ps). While recognizing its potential for short-term relief, the study shows that conditional cash transfers fail to address the structural causes of poverty such as low wages, informal employment, and lack of access to quality services. The findings suggest that government programs need to evolve beyond temporary financial assistance to include long-term solutions aimed at improving access to stable employment, education, and public services.
6. ***Theoretical Contribution to Public Administration:*** From a public administration perspective, the study contributes to the theoretical discourse by integrating social capital theory with poverty alleviation strategies. By examining the interaction between government policies, community-driven initiatives, and individual survival strategies, the research offers a holistic model that incorporates both state interventions and the grassroots efforts of families and communities. This contributes to the broader literature on public administration, particularly in the area of poverty governance and community resilience.
7. ***Policy Implications for Urban Poverty Alleviation:*** The findings provide actionable insights for policymakers, local governments, and non-governmental organizations working in urban poverty contexts. The study proposes targeted interventions to enhance social protection systems, strengthen social networks, and promote inclusive economic growth. The policy implications suggest a comprehensive approach that integrates economic empowerment, social welfare, and community development.

6.4. Broader Impact

The contribution of this research extends beyond Zamboanga City and the Philippines. It provides a model for studying urban poverty in other parts of the world, especially in low- and middle-income countries where urbanization and informal economies are on the rise. By shedding light on the lived experiences of the urban poor, this research contributes to global discussions on poverty reduction, social inequality, and the role of social networks in facilitating survival amidst systemic vulnerabilities.

In addition to advancing academic knowledge, the study aims to inform the design of more effective, targeted policies that can help reduce the vulnerability of the poorest urban populations in the Philippines and similar contexts. Ultimately, the research contributes to the growing body of work that seeks to bridge the gap between theory and practice in the field of poverty studies and public administration.

6.5. Final Remarks

The research on the economic survival of the poorest families in Zamboanga City's slum areas highlights several critical aspects of poverty and resilience. First, families primarily rely on informal employment, such as street vending and manual labor, for survival. These jobs, though essential, offer limited stability and security. Social networks within families and communities play a pivotal role, providing vital resources, job referrals, and emotional support. Despite this, these networks face limitations, particularly when urgent needs arise. The study also examines the role of government programs like 4Ps, which offer temporary relief but fail to address the root causes of poverty or provide long-term solutions. Gender dynamics are central to survival, with women shouldering much of the economic burden and engaging in both caregiving and income-generating activities. The research underscores that while these strategies offer short-term survival, they are insufficient for long-term economic mobility without structural changes in access to education, healthcare, and stable employment.

Table 9 below summarizes the key aspects of the research "Economic Survival of the Poorest Families Living in the Slum Areas of Zamboanga City, Philippines: A Phenomenological Enquiry". This table synthesizes the key findings of the study and highlights the most critical factors influencing the economic survival of families in Zamboanga City, alongside the supporting data gathered throughout the research process.

Table 9: Summary of the Key Aspects of the Research

Research Aspect	Key Findings	Implications	Supporting Data
Primary Survival Strategies	- Heavy reliance on informal employment (e.g., street vending, manual labor, and odd jobs).	- Informal economies serve as a critical, albeit unstable, source of income for poor families.	- Semi-structured interviews with 40 households; Focus group discussions.
Role of Social Networks	- Strong community and familial ties provide resources, job referrals, and emotional support.	- Social capital helps mitigate economic challenges by facilitating access to informal support.	- Observations of family and community interactions; Interviews with community leaders.
Impact of Government Support	- Government programs like 4Ps offer financial relief but are insufficient for long-term survival.	- Government programs are necessary but not sufficient to address the root causes of poverty.	- Interviews with 20 households receiving government support; local government reports.
Gendered Economic Survival	- Women are central to family survival, managing household duties and engaging in informal work.	- Gender roles influence economic activities, with women shouldering significant economic burdens.	- Gender role analysis in interviews; Household observations.
Limitations of Survival Strategies	- Informal work lacks stability; social networks sometimes cannot meet urgent needs.	- The informal economy, while vital, is fragile, and social networks face limitations in poverty alleviation.	- Cross-comparison of families with varied survival strategies.
Access to Education and Healthcare	- Limited access to formal education and healthcare constrains long-term economic mobility.	- Without education and healthcare, families face long-term challenges in escaping poverty.	- Interviews with household members; Local government health and education data.

In conclusion, this study reveals that the economic survival of the poorest families in the slum areas of Zamboanga City is contingent upon a combination of informal labor, social support systems, and government assistance. While the government plays a vital role in providing temporary relief, the limitations of current programs necessitate a shift toward a more comprehensive, inclusive, and sustainable approach to poverty alleviation. Policies that focus on job creation, education, community development, and gender equity can offer pathways to long-term economic stability for the poorest families in Zamboanga City.

By addressing the multidimensional aspects of poverty, this study advocates for a collaborative effort between government agencies, non-governmental organizations, and the communities themselves to build a more resilient and prosperous future for the marginalized populations living in urban slums. Only through such an integrated approach can the cycle of poverty be broken, ensuring that these families have the opportunity to thrive.

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